anti-terror campaigns led by the army. Although most of the three million internally displaced persons (IDPs) returned at the end of the summer, Swat's infrastructure had been badly affected, including 70 per cent of schools for girls having been destroyed.

In July 2009 the army declared Swat militant free and their operation a success. The violence seemed to reduce and ordinary Pakistanis hoped the problem had been resolved. However, a turning point came in October 2009 when shortly after Eid, a group of militants attacked the Army GHQ in Rawalpindi claiming 175 lives, with the COAS inside. The siege with hostages and shoot-out lasted eighteen hours, until the next morning. This was followed by almost daily bombings for the rest of the year, mainly in the major cities of Rawalpindi, Islamabad, Peshawar and occasionally in Lahore and Multan. In addition, a new form of fedayeen attacks where militants engaged directly with their targets by storming buildings and using suicide bombings started to become popular.[16] Lahore and other major cities had roadblocks every few kilometres. These roadblocks were the subject of further attacks. In response to the GHQ attack and the increasing violence in urban areas across Pakistan, the army launched a ground offensive entitled Rah-e-Nijat on 17 October in South Waziristan. However, not all militants were targeted and the military tried to gain the support of rival factions during this operation. North Waziristan, dominated by the Haqqani Network led by Afghan Taliban leader Sirajuddin Haqqani, which was focusing its attacks on Afghanistan, was also not targeted by the operation.

The Taliban became particularly problematic after the terror attacks on the APS Peshawar in December 2014. The attack happened after failed peace negotiations in February 2014 that instead emboldened jihadist groups further as the military continued its distinction between 'bad' and 'good' Taliban, such as the TTP's Gul Bahadur group and long-standing Afghan proxies, including Mullah Omar's Rahbari Shura, Gulbuddin Hekmatyar's Hizb-e-Islami and the Haqqani Network. Talks were abandoned after the June 2014 attack on Karachi airport which in turn led to the military operation of Zarb-e-Azb in June 2014, where the military finally went into North Waziristan to fight the TTP, the Islamic Movement of Uzbekistan, the East Turkestan Islamic Movement, Lashkar-e-Jhangvi and the Haqqani Network, who all had their bases there. Despite this operation the government was further weakened over the summer of August 2014 when both Imran Khan's PTI party and the cleric/politician Tahirul Qadri's Pakistan Awami Tehreek (PAT) led large demonstrations demanding Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif's resignation and parliament's dissolution. Sharif became